



Stored, Not Kept

Student copy (project or hand out)

The following is a reflective essay occasioned by Apple's decision to begin removing apps that are not updated, improved, or used. The writer grants the appeal of a world where what we make can simply stay, then asks whether staying is the same as being kept.

1 For most of its life the App Store worked on a quiet promise: build something once, and it could stay. A developer who made a small flashlight app over a weekend in 2009 could publish it and walk away, and the thing would sit there, downloadable, for as long as the store existed. There is a real generosity in that. It lets the work outlast the worker's attention, the way a book, once printed, outlasts the afternoon it was written in. Apple opened the store in 2008 with five hundred apps; it now holds close to two million, and a great many of them are exactly these quiet survivors, made once and left alone.

2 That permanence was a kind of equality. It meant a person of no particular standing could put a working thing into the world and have it stay in the world, on the same shelf as the work of large companies, judged by whether it was useful rather than by whether anyone kept tending it. The store took in millions of submissions a year and asked each app to clear the bar once. After that, the app was a tenant with a permanent lease.

3 This month, at its developer conference, Apple said it would change the bar. The rulebook every app must pass now warns that an app already published can be taken down, not for breaking a rule, but for sitting still: 'We may remove these apps from the App Store going forward if they are not updated, improved, or do not attract customers.' Wallpaper apps, plain timers, flashlight apps, the weekend survivors: these are the named examples. It is easy to read this as a landlord finally clearing out the quiet tenants. But the change exposes something the old promise had let us forget. A thing that is only stored is not the same as a thing that is kept.

4 To keep a thing, as opposed to storing it, is to keep working on it; the keeping is the work, not a state the work arrives at; a garden is kept and a shed is stored; a language is kept and a fact is stored; the difference is never the object but whether anyone is still bent over it.

5 What the old store offered was the shed, and we mistook the shed for permanence, even for a kind of ownership, because the app stayed where we left it. But staying is not living. Most of the two million were never really being kept by anyone; they were being remembered by a database. The store is not a library, where finished things are supposed to rest. It was always closer to a garden, and a garden does not let you walk away.

6 None of this is really about software. The unease the announcement stirs is older than any store, and it has less to do with apps than with how much of what we call having made something is just having left it

somewhere. We build, and then we hope the building counts as keeping, because keeping is harder and does not end. Maybe a place that pulls what no one tends is only admitting what was always true of made things, that they ask to be tended or they quietly stop being ours. Or maybe it is simply colder than the store that let everything stay. The comfortable years were the ones that never made us choose.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the fifth paragraph, which best characterizes the writer's position on the App Store's longtime permanence?
 - A) It offered the appearance of keeping a made thing while in fact only storing it
 - B) It was a plain mistake that the new policy rightly corrects
 - C) It mattered only to large companies and not to independent makers
 - D) It proved that made things can survive without anyone tending them
2. The writer devotes the first two paragraphs to praising the old 'build once and it stays' model primarily in order to
 - A) argue that the company should reverse its new policy
 - B) make the later turn against mere storage read as fair rather than as reflexive complaint
 - C) give readers step-by-step instructions for keeping an app available
 - D) show that the store had always treated developers unfairly

Discussion questions:

1. The writer spends two full paragraphs granting that the old model was genuinely good before turning against it. How does conceding the other side so completely change the way the later argument lands?
2. The essay turns on the difference between a thing that is 'stored' and a thing that is 'kept,' carried by the images of a shed and a garden. How does that distinction change what it means to say someone 'made something'?

Writing prompt (Q3 argument):

The writer claims that 'a thing that is only stored is not the same as a thing that is kept.' Defend, challenge, or qualify the idea that to truly keep something a person has made requires continuing to tend it, rather than simply leaving it in place. Use your own knowledge, observation, or reading.